



On-ear headphones (left) vs over-ear headphones (right)

few others can easily last you a couple of years now (depending on your usage, of course).

Let's take the Mi Dual Driver earphones as an example. Priced at merely ₹699, these inexpensive earphones offer dual 8mm and 10mm dynamic drivers that will help better cover a wider range of the frequency spectrum, an inline microphone for calls, music and call controls, and aluminium earbud housings. The same setup in a wireless pair of earphones can cost north of ₹1,000 or even ₹2,000. Additionally, there's also some level of latency and the issue of having to charge the earphones often.

Does that mean you shouldn't consider wireless earphones at all? Absolutely not! In the last couple of years, wireless earbuds have improved by leaps and bounds when it comes to wireless connectivity, codec support, sound quality, and features. In fact, due to the popularity of wireless earphones, manufacturers are putting more effort than ever into making these inexpensive yet feature-rich. So, if you're looking for earphones for just the basics like listening to music, making calls, etc., wired earphones are more inexpensive and make more sense. But if you want to dive into the world of features such as ANC, app support, and more, wireless ones are where the most action is at.

For audiophiles, wired earphones still reign supreme in a way since they offer more detail due to lesser compression. However, without a good DAC or amp to drive some of these earphones, you're cutting short their potential. So, if you aren't going to be investing in these additional equipment, it would make more sense to buy wireless earphones with advanced codecs support such as aptX or LDAC.

### ACTIVE NOISE CANCELLATION HEADPHONES/EARPHONES?

Noise-cancelling headphones, also known as active noise cancelling headphones, use processing to analyse environmental sound and generate an equal and opposite sound to essentially "cancel" it. While no ANC-enabled headphones can completely block out ambient chatter, many come close to providing high levels of isolation that wouldn't be possible with just regular old passive isolation.

Active Noise Cancellation is only important if you're someone who travels or works in noisy environments. While the ANC will not completely cancel out the sounds of traffic and your noisy co-workers, it will provide some relief and higher levels of isolation in general. So, the hum of an AC, the drone of an airplane, the background chatter in an

office, and more such noises can be reduced. However, if you're hoping for ANC headphones to cut out loud screams of infants crying, or the sound of loud mechanical keyboards clacking, you won't find much relief even with the best noise cancelling headsets. So, assess the kind of sound you're generally exposed to and want to suppress and then check reviews of the headphones to see how they handle different frequencies and types of sound.

Sometimes, just a good seal from headphones can be enough to mitigate the sounds you're exposed to. The only people we would really recommend noise-cancelling headphones to are frequent travellers. A good noise-cancelling pair of headphones or even earphones, can make a plane or car journey more pleasant. Over-ear models, however, work the best since they already passively block a fair amount of noise due to their design and if you add ANC to that, you're looking at pretty efficient noise-cancelling. Also, it makes sense to first try out ANC headphones for yourself since some people can find the plugged up feeling of ANC headphones uncomfortable and disorienting. So, it is best to try it out first before potentially wasting your money on headphones that may not suit you. **d**